Second, ever since the famous paper by PBOC Governor Zhou Xiaochuan, released in March 2009 prior to the G20 London Summit, which advocated the increased use of SDR,[161] the Chinese government has been advocating the inclusion of the RMB into the SDR, the IMF's virtual currency. Since 1969, the SDR has supplemented global liquidity and been used for IMF transactions, functioning as both a unit of account and a store of value. The SDR was long based on a "currency basket" that includes the world's four major hard currencies: the U.S. dollar, the euro, the Japanese yen, and the British pound sterling.[162] The composition of the SDR is reviewed every five years, and it requires a 70 percent majority among the IMF EDs' votes to revise the currency composition.

Although Governor Zhou's proposal was a practical policy suggestion regarding the wider use of SDR, many took it, probably correctly, as a Chinese challenge to U.S. dollar dominance.[163] The IMF Articles of Agreement specify that a currency may qualify to be included in the SDR when it is "freely usable." This usability consists of two components: it should be "widely used to make payments for international transactions" and "widely traded in the principal exchange markets."[164] When the Chinese government began to make some moves toward including the RMB in the SDR, the IMF's 2010 review found this premature.[165] But given China's increasing weight in the economy in the 2010s, the G20 at its Cannes Summit in November 2011 took it upon itself to recommend to the IMF that the question of SDR composition be revisited. The BRICS governments at the July 2015 BRICS leaders' summit at Ufa, Russia supported China on including the RMB in the SDR in order to "counter Western dominance of the IMF."[166] Then on November 30, 2015, the EDs of the IMF completed their review and determined that the RMB meets the existing currency selection criteria for the SDR basket, and its inclusion was effected as of October 1, 2016.

The revised SDR basket is now based on the following weights: 41.73 percent for the U.S. dollar; 30.93 percent for the euro; 10.92 percent for the Chinese RMB; 8.33 percent for the Japanese yen, and 8.09 percent for the British pound. These weights are derived from a new formula adopted by the IMF EDs in their review, including the value of the issuers' exports, the amount of reserves denominated in the respective currencies that were held by other monetary authorities, foreign exchange turnover, and international bank liabilities and international debt securities denominated in the respective